

Artificial Indian

NOT ONE PERSON READING THIS COLUMN IS UNAWARE OF THE RACE TOWARDS AI.

Artificial Intelligence is, after all, the pinnacle of the computing journey. That said, AI is now a common buzzword that marketers use to sell you stuff. Every phone you buy, every service you subscribe to or use, they all claim to be AI powered, and in most cases, they're not wrong. Machine intelligence is actually being used for *everything* these days. The problem is that AI can be used to describe a ton of things. Excel suggesting a correction to your formula is an example of AI. Spell check or autocorrect is AI, as are the machines that beat grandmasters at Chess, or other mind games that we humans used to pride ourselves at.

For every aspect of our humanity we're being led around by AI. The IT giants are making trillions by using AI to track us and tailor advertising to us, because some algorithm somewhere, in some machine, mimics you and a few others like you, and tries to hone its skills at predicting what you would like. AI learns with data, and the more data it feeds on the more accurate it becomes.

While it is true that humans are not as unique and special as they believe themselves to be. What I mean by this is that while we all believe we're one in a million, in a world with 7 billion people on it, all you're really saying is that there are 6999 people out there who are just like you. And let's face it, when it comes to likes and dislikes and buying stuff, that's more like 7 million other people who are just like you.

AI groups us all together in buckets. And the goal is to keep making those buckets smaller and smaller, and thus more and more accurate. We're always increasing the computing power we have, which is what makes all this bucket shrinking possible.

And that's where the problem starts.

All of us, without exception, have a cultural heritage. Now that can be led by religion, geographical boundaries, weird belief systems, the morals of our parents, of the city we live in, how much money our parents earn, or even by the colour of our skin, there are many factors that go into deciding who we turn out to be, and it's not all based on genetics.

While both cities are metros, the experience of growing up in New Delhi vs growing up in Mumbai, is very different. And not just because

of the local language spoken around you. There are a million little things that go into the human experience and if we're to ever build a general AI (one that can pass for a human), this is one area of research that's proving hard to avoid.

And no, I do not mean that this cultural aspect of AI is impossible to code for. I'm saying that it's impossible to uncode for!

Think about it this way. A Chinese built AI will be accurate in China. It will possess a Chinese-biased cultural aspect that will eventually lead to even more bias. A simple thought experiment you can run is to consider a Chinese-built AI that sorts through and picks good looking landscape photographs from submissions and sites all over the globe. Assuming this was built in China, and subjected to learning data that was pretty much just photographs from all across China, when you unleash it on the world it will be able to rank good looking photos from, say, the US, but it might have an undetectable bias towards scenes that remind it of home.

Now, remember that this is a very human quality. We all love places that remind us of home, so why have a problem if an AI we build also has a small preference for places that remind it of 'home'? And that's a debate worth having. I'm not sure I can pick a side just yet. A part of me wants a very human AI, and hundreds and thousands of individual AIs with quirky personalities and actual differences in characters and temperament and even interests. Another part of me then remembers how fast quirks can become mental illnesses and how some of us quirky humans are psychopathic killers...

Still, the cultural aspect of AI is impossible to ignore. And what's worse, this might soon (or may already have) result in an AI race of sorts that is reminiscent of the arms race between the US and the USSR. This time it's between the Chinese and the Americans, but every other country is also in the race to try and build the ultimate AI. India is too, and I'm really hoping thousands of Indian kids graduating after this weird year we've had will go down the path of becoming AI researchers.

It's bad enough that today's technology doesn't understand our accents and languages, imagine what a crap experience it will be to have to deal with tomorrow's AI that is Chinese or American biased? 🇮🇳



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